



INNOVATIONS IN FINANCE

CAPSTONE PROJECT

Make an impact



INTRODUCTION



Make an impact



TWO WEEKS BEFORE YOU CHOOSE

Today is preparation. The partners present their own subjects on 16 September.

A real question, from a real company, that nobody has answered yet.

WHAT THIS IS NOT

Not a teaching case with a known answer at the back.

Not an exercise built to make a method look good.

Not something you can complete by reading and summarising.

WHAT IT IS

A question two companies have put on the table because they have not settled it themselves.

They will be in the room on 16 September, and again on 2 December. That changes what a good answer looks like.

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH TODAY

You know how the capstone runs, you know what the three subjects are, and you have written down the questions you want to put to the partners on 16 September.





WHY A CAPSTONE, AND WHY NOW

Eight sessions on how the mechanisms work. One project that uses them.

Sessions 1 to 8

How payments, data, AI, APIs and regulation actually work, and how they are assembled into fintech products

Understanding

The capstone

You apply that understanding to a question a company has genuinely put on the table

Application

The difference

A course answer is judged on whether it is correct. A recommendation is judged on whether somebody could act on it.

And that is what gets marked

WHAT CARRIES OVER FROM THE COURSE

You now know how these systems are built, who operates each layer, where the money moves and what the rules require. Both partners have handed you questions that sit exactly on that ground. You are not starting from a blank page: you are starting from a working model of the industry.





THREE SUBJECTS, TWO PARTNERS

Read the bottom row before you fall in love with a topic

Subject 1 : Veolia

RETROSPECTIVE

How do the Water Technologies and Clean Earth acquisitions fit into Veolia's multi-dimensional performance model?

Corporate finance and ESG measurement

Everything is published. The difficulty is reading it.

Subject 2 : Veolia

PROSPECTIVE

Which activities, geographies and acquisitions should Veolia favour in 2026-2027 to reach its GreenUp targets?

Corporate finance and strategy

An open question. Nobody has the answer yet, including Veolia.

Subject 3 : Linxo

PRODUCT

Which PFM features would a young audience expect, and what gamification can be built around budgeting and saving?

Product, UX and business model

Almost nothing is published. You generate the material.

Two of these are about reading what exists. One is about creating what does not. Choose accordingly.





WHAT YOU WILL BE ABLE TO DO

Five things, and only one of them is about your subject

1

Turn an open question into a closed one

The brief you are given is broader than what you can do. Narrowing it, and defending the narrowing, is the first skill.

2

Build an evidence base and know its limits

Where the data came from, what it does not cover, and what you had to assume.

3

Commit to a recommendation

With its cost, who bears it, and what would make you change your mind.

4

Defend it to someone who knows more than you

The partner is in the room. They will not be impressed by confidence.

5

And say what you could not establish

The single most reliable marker of a group that did the work.

None of these depends on which subject you pick. That is deliberate.





HOW IT WORKS



Make an impact



GROUPS OF FIVE TO SIX

Large enough to do real work, large enough for two people to hide

WHAT A GROUP OF SIX CAN DO

Cover a subject properly. Split a hundred pages of source documents.
Interview enough people for the answers to mean something.

Genuinely more than the sum of six individual assignments.

WHAT A GROUP OF SIX ALSO DOES

Concentrates the work on two people while four attend.

It is not a character flaw. It is what happens by default when nobody owns anything in particular, and it happens in companies too.

SO THE DEFAULT IS REMOVED

Every group splits into six named roles, listed on the next slide. Each of you owns one and defends it alone in front of the jury. In a group of five, role six is shared.

Twenty-five percent of your mark is individual, and it is decided in those two minutes of questions.





THE SIX ROLES

Same shape on all three subjects, the content differs, the structure does not

1

Scope and evidence

Defines what is in and out. Builds and owns the source base.

2

Core analysis

The central piece of work: the measurement, the model, or the research.

3

The hard one

Every subject has a block that is harder than the rest. Session detail later.

4

Cost and economics

What the recommendation costs, to whom, and whether it pays.

5

Rules and constraints

Regulation, accounting, data protection, whichever applies to your subject.

6

Synthesis, tool and pitch

Holds the whole together. Detects when roles 2 and 4 contradict each other.

Role 6 is not secretarial. It is the only role that sees the contradictions.





TWO DELIVERABLES

One that everybody produces, and one that has to be earned

The written report

EVERY GROUP. NON-NEGOTIABLE.

- Length as specified in your subject brief
- One section per role, signed by its author
- Every figure traceable to an attached file
- A recommendation, not a summary
- And what you could not establish

The oral defence

TOP THREE REPORTS PER SUBJECT ONLY

- Twenty minutes of presentation
- Ten minutes of questions
- Questions addressed to a named role
- Jury includes people from the partner
- Selection is made on the report alone

THE CONSEQUENCE, AND PLAN AROUND IT

Selection is made on the written report alone. There is no pitch that rescues a weak report, and no oral that you can prepare instead of writing. The report is what you are building from week one.

Groups that spend November on slides and December on the report get this backwards, every year.





HOW YOU ARE ASSESSED

Three quarters collective, one quarter yours alone

Written report	30 %	COLLECTIVE	Diagnosis, evidence, recommendation, and honesty about limits.
Analytical depth of the core work	25 %	COLLECTIVE	The central piece of analysis, whichever subject you are on.
Oral defence, coherence and clarity	20 %	COLLECTIVE	For groups selected. Otherwise redistributed across the written work.
Individual defence of your role	25 %	INDIVIDUAL	Mastery, honesty, and how your workstream changed the conclusion.

The detailed marking grid is handed out at the first checkpoint, not at the end. You are meant to write against it.





FOUR CHECKPOINTS

At each one you show an object, not an intention

1	22 SEPT	Scope closed	Roles named. Question in one written sentence. What is out of scope, in writing.
2	7 OCT	Evidence loaded	The sources are downloaded and read, or the first interviews are done. No analysis expected.
3	16 OCT	Questions ready	Not a checkpoint but a partner session. You arrive with precise questions or you waste the only access you get.
4	17 NOV	Full draft	Every section written, every figure sourced. Not a plan, a draft. Eight days before submission.

Nothing is scheduled between 16 October and 17 November. That gap is where projects quietly die.





THE DATES

Three months. Put all of them in your calendar before you leave.

Today	THIS SESSION	How it works, and what the three subjects are
16 Sept	PARTNERS	Veolia and Linxo present their own subjects
18 Sept	CHOICE	You commit to a subject
22 Sept	TD 1	Checkpoint 1: scope closed
7 Oct	TD 2	Checkpoint 2: evidence loaded
16 Oct	PARTNERS	Your questions to their teams
17 Nov	TD 3	Checkpoint 4: full draft
25 Nov	SUBMISSION	Written report due
2 Dec	DEFENCE	Top three per subject, jury includes the partner
Six weeks with nothing scheduled between 16 October and 17 November. Plan for it.		





EVERY NUMBER, TRACEABLE

The rule that decides more marks than any other

A figure without a source is treated as a figure you invented.

What counts as a source

A document you attach. URL, date consulted, and the raw file in your annexe.

What does not

A secondary site quoting a number without its origin. A consultancy infographic. A figure from a previous year's report.

Where students lose marks

Not by being wrong. By being unable to say where a number came from when asked.

And the one that matters most

Numbers produced by a language model. The model builds the tool that calculates. It does not calculate.

Session 5's rule, applied to a semester of work. It has cost professionals their licences.





AI: ALLOWED, ENCOURAGED, DOCUMENTED

You spent a session on this. Now use it properly.

USE IT FOR

- Building the tool that does the calculation
- Structuring and cleaning source data
- Drafting and challenging your own arguments
- Prototyping an interface
- Asking what a reviewer would criticise

NEVER USE IT FOR

- Producing a number
- Producing a source
- Producing a quote from a document
- Summarising a document you have not opened
- Writing the part you do not understand

AND ONE PAGE IN THE ANNEXE

Which tools you used, and for what. This is not a confession. It is an assessed competence. A group that used AI well and says how will score better than a group that used it well and hid it.

The last item on the right is the real line: never ship the part you cannot explain.





THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN TWO REPORTS

Both reach a favourable conclusion. Only one did the work.

THE COMPLACENT REPORT

Takes the brief's framing as given.

Uses the partner's own definitions without asking what they include.

Reaches the conclusion the brief implied.

Is well written, well presented, and adds nothing the partner did not already know.

Cannot be contradicted by any observation, which is why it cannot be marked highly.

THE REPORT THAT GETS PICKED

Narrows the brief and says why.

Tests the partner's framing against something external.

Reaches a conclusion that could have gone the other way.

Says which part of the result is solid and which rests on an assumption.

Tells the partner something they had not seen, which is the entire point of asking outsiders.

THE TEST, AND YOU CAN APPLY IT TO YOUR OWN DRAFT

Could your report have reached the opposite conclusion? If no observation you could have made would have changed your answer, you have not analysed anything, you have described something.





PARTNER ONE: VEOLIA



Make an impact



VEOLIA AT A GLANCE

The 2025 financial year, as published in February 2026

€44.4bn

Revenue 2025

+1.4% at constant scope and forex

15.9%

EBITDA margin

up 70 basis points

+6.3%

Organic EBITDA growth

above the 5-6% target range

9.4%

ROCE after tax

GreenUp target, two years early

Listed

Euronext Paris, member of the SBF 120 and the Fortune 500

People

215,000 employees on five continents

Three businesses

Water, waste, including hazardous waste, and local energy

Scale, in 2025

110 million people supplied with drinking water, 97 million with sanitation, 45 million MWh produced, 64 million tonnes of waste treated

Balance sheet

BBB / Baa1, with a public commitment to keep it





WHAT VEOLIA ACTUALLY SELLS

Three businesses, and one of them is about to matter a great deal

Water

Municipal distribution and treatment, plus industrial water technologies sold to manufacturers.

Long concessions, regulated, predictable.

Waste

Collection, sorting, recycling, and, the part that matters here, hazardous waste treatment.

Permits are scarce. That scarcity is the whole story.

Local energy

District heating and cooling, energy efficiency for buildings and industry, biomass.

The least documented of the three.

WHY HAZARDOUS WASTE IS WHERE BOTH SUBJECTS LAND

You cannot build a permitted incinerator any more. Growth means buying somebody who already holds the permits.





GREENUP: THE PLAN YOU ARE BEING ASKED ABOUT

2024 to 2027, with financial and environmental targets side by side

THE FINANCIAL TARGETS

- EBITDA of at least €8bn in 2027 (€6.8bn in 2024)
- Organic growth of around 5% a year
- €4bn earmarked for acquisitions over 2023-2027
- Leverage at or slightly above 3x in 2026
- Leverage at or below 3x in 2027

THE ENVIRONMENTAL TARGETS

- 18 Mt of CO2e emissions avoided
- 1.5 billion m³ of water saved
- 9 Mt of hazardous waste treated
- Measured through the group's own framework

THAT FRAMEWORK HAS A NAME, AND YOU WILL NEED TO UNDERSTAND IT

Veolia measures itself across five dimensions, economic, commercial, social, societal and environmental, through 19 indicators tied to 18 progress objectives, reported against five stakeholder groups. The group designed all of it.

That last sentence is not a criticism. It is the fact that makes subject 1 interesting.





TWO ACQUISITIONS, FULLY DOCUMENTED

Prices, multiples, synergies, accretion dates, all public

	Water Technologies	Clean Earth
What	The 30% held by CDPQ, bought out	Acquired from Enviri Corporation, listed on the NYSE
Price	\$1.75bn, about €1.5bn	\$3.04bn, about €2.6bn
Multiple	~11x EV / 2025 EBITDA post-synergies	~9.8x 2026e EBITDA post-synergies
Closed	End of June 2025	1 June 2026
Synergies	~€90m run-rate by 2027	\$120m by year four
Accretion	From 2026	EPS from 2027, before purchase price allocation

PLUS THREE SMALL ONES, ANNOUNCED 26 JUNE 2025

New England Disposal Technologies and New England MedWaste in Massachusetts, Ingenium in California. No price published for any of them, and that is itself informative.





SUBJECT 1



Make an impact



SUBJECT 1 : THE BRIEF

Integrating strategic acquisitions into Veolia's multi-dimensional ESG performance

PROJECT TITLE

"From acquisition to impact: how do Veolia's investments in Water Technologies (CDPQ) and Clean Earth, together with the other tuck-ins announced to the market in 2024 and 2025, strengthen the group's multi-dimensional performance strategy?"

CENTRAL QUESTION

How do the Water Technologies and Clean Earth acquisitions fit into Veolia's multi-dimensional performance model, and what contribution do they make to the group's 2027 ESG targets?

CONTEXT

These deals form a significant share of the €2.8bn invested in M&A, with 79% allocated to the growth boosters.

DELIVERABLES

Written report of 40 to 50 pages. Oral defence of 20 minutes plus 10 minutes of questions, for the three best reports.

WHAT VEOLIA IS BUYING BY ASKING OUTSIDERS

An independent read on whether the capital they deployed delivers what they have committed to publicly, and where the evidence is thin.





SUBJECT 1 : THE THREE RESEARCH QUESTIONS

Veolia's own structure. Your report answers these.

1

ESG contribution

What do these acquisitions contribute to Veolia's ESG KPIs: emissions avoided, water saved, hazardous waste treated?

And how do the assets sit across the four performance pillars: environmental, commercial, social, HR?

2

Multi-stakeholder value creation

How do these acquisitions create value for each stakeholder category, within the distribution of €44.7bn of revenue?

What is the impact on the current split: 25% employees, 64% suppliers and levies, 7% depreciation, 1 to 2% shareholders?

3

Synergies and integration

Which operational and ESG synergies can be generated with the existing portfolio?

And how are the ESG best practices of these entities brought into the group?

Question 2 has the most interesting arithmetic in the subject. Look carefully at the denominator.





SUBJECT 1 : THE TIMELINE YOU ARE WORKING WITH

The two deals are at very different stages, and that shapes your method

Water Technologies	Closed end of June 2025	Eighteen months of ownership by December. Genuinely retrospective.
Clean Earth, announced	21 November 2025	
Clean Earth, closed	1 June 2026	One month of consolidation in the 2026 half-year accounts.
First full reporting	FY 2026, seven months, published February 2027	After you submit on 25 November.

SO THE TWO CASES CALL FOR TWO DIFFERENT METHODS

Water Technologies can be assessed after the fact. Clean Earth is best handled as an ex ante baseline: what the business was worth, what it earned, what its indicators were, and what will need to be watched as the integration runs.





SUBJECT 1 : THE SELLER IS LISTED IN NEW YORK

Nobody will find this unless you tell them to look

Clean Earth was sold by Enviri Corporation, listed on the New York Stock Exchange.

WHAT THAT MEANS IN PRACTICE

Enviri reported Clean Earth as a segment, under SEC disclosure rules, right up to the sale.

Revenue, EBITDA, margins, capital employed, several years of history, all public, all auditable.

WHY IT WILL NOT STAY AVAILABLE

Inside Veolia, Clean Earth disappears into the hazardous waste segment.

This is better information than Veolia will publish about the asset for years, and it stops being reconstructable once integration is done.

WHICH IS ALSO WHY IT IS WORTH SOMETHING TO THE PARTNER

A rigorous ex ante baseline, built from the seller's filings, against which to measure the integration in two years. Nobody inside has time to produce it, and in eighteen months it will no longer be possible.





SUBJECT 1 : THE TONNE THAT DID NOT MOVE

The analytical heart of the subject, in one example

One of the GreenUp targets: 9 million tonnes of hazardous waste treated.

1

Veolia buys Clean Earth, a hazardous waste company.

2

Tonnage treated by the group goes up.

3

The indicator improves. The target gets closer.

4

But those tonnes were already being treated the day before, by Clean Earth, under Enviri, in the same plants, by the same 2,600 people.

Veolia's indicator moved. The phenomenon it is meant to measure did not move by a gram.

This is an attribution problem, and separating perimeter effect from real change is the work.





SUBJECT 1 : READ IT THROUGH CSRD

The regulatory frame Veolia reports under, used as your second lens

Every group tests the group's own framework against CSRD double materiality. This is required.

What CSRD requires

Reporting on two directions at once: how sustainability issues affect the company, and how the company's activity affects people and the environment.

Why the second half matters here

"How the company's activity affects the world" is precisely the attribution question, turned into a legal obligation rather than a matter of choice.

What it lets you do

Take the impact figures from research question 1 and ask whether they would survive a double materiality assessment. Same numbers, different frame, different reading.

And it is not an outside imposition

Veolia reports under CSRD. You are reading their performance through a standard they are already held to.

Two lenses on the same performance. Where they disagree is where your analysis lives.





SUBJECT 1 : THE SIX ROLES

And the trap waiting for each of them

1

Perimeter and evidence

The two deals plus three named tuck-ins. Nothing else.

Closing the scope is the job. Open scope means an unmarkable report.

2

Impact contribution

Estimate what these assets contribute to the 2027 targets.

It is an estimate, not a measurement. Say so, with a method and a range.

3

Financial justification

Do ~11x and ~9.8x hold up against the announced synergies?

The hard one. There will be a workshop on reading a transaction multiple.

4

Value distribution

How value splits across stakeholders, and whether the published ratio holds.

Check what the denominator is. That is where the answer hides.

5

External reference

Confront the in-house framework with your assigned outside yardstick.

The gap is the finding. Explaining it is the deliverable.

6

Synthesis and defence

Holds the report together and spots internal contradictions.

If roles 2 and 3 disagree, you are the only one who will notice.





SUBJECT 2



Make an impact



SUBJECT 2 : THE BRIEF

A 2026-2027 development strategy to reach the GreenUp targets

PROJECT TITLE

"GreenUp 2027 trajectory: which strategic orientations and acquisitions can close the gap and maximise Veolia's ESG contribution?"

CENTRAL QUESTION

Which activities, geographies and types of acquisition should Veolia favour in 2026-2027 to reach its GreenUp targets while maximising its ESG contribution and multi-dimensional performance?

WHY THIS ONE IS WORTH TAKING

It is a genuinely open question. There is no settled answer inside Veolia either, which means a well argued recommendation is of real use to them.

WHERE TO START

The brief's own third research question asks how to arbitrate between organic and external growth. Establish the capacity first, then allocate it.

DELIVERABLES

Written report of 50 to 60 pages. Oral defence of 20 minutes plus 10 minutes of questions, for the three best reports.





SUBJECT 2 : THE FOUR RESEARCH QUESTIONS

Veolia's own structure. Your report answers these.

1

Strategic gap

What is the gap between the current trajectory and the 2027 targets on EBITDA, growth and ESG KPIs? Which segments and geographies over or under perform?

2

Benchmark and market opportunities

Which players and segments contribute most to ESG in each booster? Which regulatory and market trends help? What multiples and synergies do recent sector deals show?

3

Allocating the remaining capital

How to arbitrate between organic capex and external growth? What split between boosters and strongholds? Which selection criteria maximise ESG impact per euro invested?

4

Strategic orientations

Reinforce existing geographies or open new ones? Which emerging technologies to integrate? How to accelerate synergies, which rose from €398m in 2024 to a €530m objective?

Question 3 is the one everything else feeds into.



SUBJECT 2 : SIZING THE CAPACITY

Work backwards from the 2027 commitments, then allocate what is there

THE COMMITMENT

Leverage at or below 3x in 2027

EBITDA target $\geq$ €8bn

→ **Maximum net debt $\approx$ €24bn**

THE STARTING POINT

Net financial debt, 30 June 2025

€20,764m

Net financial debt, 30 June 2026

€24,548m

Even if the EBITDA target is met, the group has to reduce debt to keep its promise, not increase it.

HANDLE WITH CARE

June debt is seasonally high, since dividends and working capital land in the first half, and the group generates cash over the year. The order of magnitude is right; the precision is your job.

AND THE PARAMETER THAT DOMINATES

Every €0.5bn of EBITDA unlocks €1.5bn of permitted debt at 3x. Capacity depends more on hitting the EBITDA target than on any allocation decision you make.



SUBJECT 2 : HOW THE WORK IS DIVIDED

Each group takes one perimeter, so the reports are comparable

30% of groups	Water technologies	Listed comparables, and the effect of the 30% buy-out on margin and ROCE.
30% of groups	Hazardous waste	US listed comparables, with Clean Harbors as the direct one. Effect of Clean Earth, and what room is left in the segment.
20% of groups	Bioenergy and efficiency	The least documented booster, so the one where serious work adds the most.
20% of groups	Financial capacity	The transverse perimeter: how much is available to allocate. Detailed next.

The groups working on capacity produce the number the others have to fit inside. Compare your allocation against it.





SUBJECT 2 : THE CAPACITY WORKSTREAM

Five blocks, and every other group is waiting on the output

1

Reconstruct what has been spent

€4bn was announced. What has actually gone out, and was that envelope gross or net of disposals? The brief does not say.

2

Establish the starting position

Net debt, EBITDA, debt maturity profile. Find Veolia's own leverage definition rather than inventing one.

3

Turn the commitments into a number

Work backwards from the 2027 constraint. And read the rating agencies' published downgrade triggers, that is the real limit.

4

Model the three sources of capacity

Free cash flow, disposals under the asset rotation programme, and the residual leverage headroom.

5

Test the sensitivity

Which input moves the answer most? You already know. Prove it.

This workstream publishes its range in early November. Everyone else calibrates on it.





PARTNER TWO: LINXO



Make an impact



LINXO AT A GLANCE

A French open banking pioneer, now inside a very large bank

~3m

Users in France

one of the largest PFM bases in the country

~1 in 3

Use it as their main banking app

not as a secondary tool

100%

Owned by Crédit Agricole

via Crédit Agricole Payment Services

2 sides

Consumer app and B2B APIs

Linxo Connect, plus white label

What it does

Account aggregation and personal financial management, pulls your accounts into one place, categorises transactions, builds budgets

How it connects

Through PSD2 access, which you spent a session on. Linxo was one of the first in France to build on it

The B2B arm

Linxo Connect sells account access, payment initiation and PFM as APIs to other companies; Oxlin does white label

The ownership

Crédit Agricole Payment Services took over 85% in June 2020 and reached 100% in 2025





A FINTECH INSIDE A BANK

Which is exactly the position we spent session 6 arguing about

The disruptor was bought by the incumbent. Both of them think they won.

WHAT THE BANK BOUGHT

A relationship with three million people, a technology stack it could not build quickly, and a foothold in a layer that was starting to sit between banks and their customers.

Also: it stops being a competitor.

WHAT THE FINTECH GOT

Balance sheet, regulatory shelter, distribution, and an owner who can absorb years of investment.

Also: a shareholder with views about which customers matter.

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR YOUR SUBJECT

You are designing for 18-25s, people who are not yet profitable, who churn, and who may become customers of the parent group for forty years. Whose problem are you actually solving? That question has more than one honest answer.





SUBJECT 3



Make an impact



SUBJECT 3 : THE BRIEF

Four phases, from listening to a business case

LINXO'S QUESTION

Which PFM features would a young audience expect, and what gamification can be built around budgeting and saving?

1

Empathy

Understand the gap

Personas and empathy map

2

Ideation

Turn needs into mechanics

Ranked feature catalogue

3

Prototype

Make it visible and testable

Working prototype

4

Business model

Prove it can pay for itself

Business case and roadmap

WHAT MAKES THIS HARD, AND IT IS NOT THE DESIGN

Nothing is published. There is no dataset waiting for you. Every input to phases 1 and 2 is material you have to go and create.





PHASE 1 : EMPATHY

The phase that decides whether the other three are worth anything

WHAT YOU DO

- Comparative study: Revolut, Finary, and the rest
- Qualitative interviews with real 18-25 year olds
- Enough of them that patterns appear, not anecdotes
- Including people who tried an app and stopped
- Especially those. They know why it failed.

WHAT YOU DELIVER

A detailed persona and an empathy map: what they actually worry about, what they want, what they avoid.

Built from what people said, not from what your group assumes 20-year-olds think, and you are 20-year-olds, which is the trap.

YOU ARE ASKING PEOPLE ABOUT THEIR MONEY. HANDLE IT PROPERLY.

Tell them what the interview is for, who will see it, and how long you keep the recording. Get consent, in writing, before you record. Anonymise before anything leaves your group. Personal financial data is not ordinary interview material, and the person asking is responsible.

THE VALUE LINXO IS ACTUALLY BUYING HERE

An unfiltered view of how young people see these products, from people young enough that they will be told the truth.





PHASE 2 : IDEATION AND MECHANICS

Three families of mechanic, suggested by Linxo, to be tested by you

Micro-saving

Automatic round-ups pushed into named projects, a trip, a festival, a deposit.

Works because the amounts are invisible. Fails when the goal is abstract.

Social finance

Challenges between friends. Anonymised comparison, "you spent 10% less on fast food than the average student in your city".

Powerful, and the most double-edged thing in the brief.

Rewards

Smart cashback, saver levels, streaks and status.

Cheap to build, easy to game, and the fastest to lose credibility.

THE DELIVERABLE

A feature catalogue, ranked by impact and by feasibility. Ranking is the work, a list of twenty ideas is not a catalogue.





PHASE 3 : PROTOTYPE

Make it visible enough that somebody can disagree with it

WHAT IS EXPECTED

- Wireframes, or an interactive prototype
- Figma is the obvious tool, and it is free
- Low or high fidelity, both are acceptable
- The key journeys, not every screen
- Tested on real people from phase 1

THE QUESTION IT MUST ANSWER

What makes somebody open this tomorrow?

Linxo calls it the daily habit, and it is the hardest thing in consumer product. Most finance apps are opened when something is wrong.

AND THE HONEST VERSION OF THAT QUESTION

There is a difference between an app someone opens because it is useful and an app someone opens because it engineered a compulsion. Both produce the same daily active user number. Only one of them survives contact with a regulator.

Session 8 applies here: it does not have to be beautiful, it has to be testable.





PHASE 4 : BUSINESS MODEL AND GO-TO-MARKET

The phase that separates a nice idea from a proposal

MONETISATION

- Freemium, what exactly is behind the wall?
- Affinity brand partnerships, routed through the PFM data
- What a user of this age is actually worth
- And over what horizon

ACQUISITION

- TikTok and the channels this segment actually uses
- Student union and campus partnerships
- What it costs to acquire one user
- And how many stay past month three

THE QUESTION YOUR BUSINESS CASE HAS TO ANSWER HONESTLY

The product is free for the user. So who pays? If the answer is brand partnerships routed through transaction data, then the app that sees everything you buy is also the app being paid to influence what you buy next. Say that out loud in your report.

This is the hardest of the four phases for a business school group, and it is where the marks are.





SUBJECT 3 : THE FIFTH DELIVERABLE

Not in Linxo's brief. Required anyway.

Which mechanics did you consider and rule out, and why?

WHY THIS IS REQUIRED

You are designing engagement mechanics, social comparison and reward loops, aimed at 18-25 year olds, around their money.

That is either genuinely useful or quietly harmful, and the difference is entirely in the design choices.

WHAT IT IS NOT

Not a paragraph of ethical hand-wringing at the end.

A page listing specific mechanics you designed, tested against your personas, and decided not to ship, with the reason.

AND IT IS WORTH SOMETHING TO LINXO

This is the question a regulator or a journalist will ask them eventually. Better it arrives first from a group of students, with the reasoning already done.





SUBJECT 3 : THE SIX ROLES

Same structure, different content

1

Field research

Recruits, interviews, transcribes, and owns consent and anonymisation.

2

Synthesis and personas

Turns interviews into patterns. Resists the temptation to describe the group itself.

3

Business model

The hard one. Monetisation, unit economics, retention, and who actually pays.

4

Mechanics and feature catalogue

Designs, ranks, and documents what was ruled out.

5

Prototype and testing

Builds it and puts it in front of real users.

6

Synthesis, business case and pitch

Holds it together. Checks the prototype still matches the research.

Role 3 is the hard one here, and it is the role that decides whether this is a proposal or a mood board.





CHOOSING



Make an impact



WHICH ONE IS FOR YOU

Be honest about how your group works, not about what sounds impressive

Subject 1, Veolia, retrospective

Reading annual reports and segment notes, estimating with a method, arguing about measurement.

If your group likes structured evidence and careful argument.

Subject 2, Veolia, prospective

Balance sheets, leverage, credit constraints, and an allocation decision under a hard ceiling.

If you want the most technically financial of the three.

Subject 3, Linxo

Talking to strangers, designing, prototyping, and then proving it can pay for itself.

If your group will actually interview twenty people before 7 October.

The last column is the real question. Choose the one your group will actually do, not the one that sounds best in a bar.





AND WHAT YOU HAVE AFTERWARDS

Six months from now, in an interview, what can you actually say?

Subject 1

"I valued two acquisitions against their announced synergies and tested a company's own impact framework against an external benchmark."

ESG analysis, corporate finance, audit

Subject 2

"I worked out how much a listed group could actually invest under its leverage and rating commitments, and where it should go."

M&A, credit, corporate finance, equity research

Subject 3

"I researched a segment, designed and prototyped a product for it, and built the business case that showed whether it paid."

Product, consulting, venture, marketing

All three sentences are true only if you did the hard part. That is rather the point.





THREE THINGS, WHATEVER YOU CHOOSE

The same three, on all three subjects

1

Every number traceable

To a document you attach. An unsourced figure is treated as an invented one, including when it comes from a model.

2

A decision you own

Not a summary of options. A recommendation, its cost, who bears it, and what would make you change your mind.

3

And the question from the course

Who pays, and what does the indicator actually measure? Neither brief asks it. That is exactly why it is your contribution.

And the self-test from earlier: could your report have reached the opposite conclusion?





BETWEEN NOW AND 16 SEPTEMBER

Four things, and the first one happens in the next ten minutes

1

Now, in this room

Write down the questions you want to ask Veolia and Linxo on 16 September. Hand them to me before you leave.

2

Before 16 September

Read the three briefs properly and form your group. Turning up to the partner session cold wastes it.

3

18 September

You commit to a subject. Two days after the partners speak, so the conversation happens on the way out of that room.

4

22 September

Checkpoint 1. Six roles named, your question in one sentence, and what is out of scope. All in writing.

Two companies are coming in to talk to you. Show up with something to ask them.





Make an impact

